NO LIMITS FOR SKY

SPORT CRICKET'S MODERN MAESTRO

SURYAKUMAR YADAV
Indian cricketer

On the periphery of the Kensington Oval in Barbados last summer, Suryakumar Yadav executed a manoeuvre that pierced the gossamer divide between triumph and despair. Leaping near the boundary rope, catching a ball that seemed destined for the lower bleachers—it was pure cricketing ballet. "I've watched it more than 222 times," Yadav confessed at the India Today Conclave, reflecting on the catch that culminated in India's T20 World Cup victory. The moment serves as an apt metaphor for his career—a study in calculated risk and meticulous preparation. Once dismissed as "one-dimensional", Yadav's transformation into a 360-degree batsman and subsequently India's T20 captain is a compelling narrative. "At the end of the 2018 season, I realised the things I need to do if I want to be the best," Yadav recounted. A reconstructed fitness regimen was put in place, nutritional discipline followed, with a monastic dedication to his craft.

Yadav's philosophy as captain mirrors this: boldness tempered with strategic intention. Under his stewardship, India's T20 team has approached the previously unthinkable 300-run mark. "We decided, if two batters get 75-75 and we're getting about 180-190, how about seven batters trying to split that and get 12-ball 30s each?" he recalled.

As India prepares to host the next T20 World Cup in 2026, in Yadav's philosophy, cricket transcends statistics. "Whatever happens, you win or you learn." ■

To watch the full session, visit https://bitly.cx/r5IX3

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **SKY's trademark shots were not flashes of brilliance but the product of relentless practice—rehearsed "10,000, 20,000 times" until they were instinctive**
- **Rather than depending on a few to score 75 runs each to reach 180-190, Yadav as captain encourages seven batters to aim to contribute "12-ball 30s"**

Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**



> **First you dream about playing for India, then you dream that you want to do something special, and then comes that one day when you lead your country**

> **I was called a one-dimensional player. To reach the top, I changed my diet, cut down on friends, started training...in 2019-20, I played a lot of domestic cricket. In 2021, I got the fruits of what I did for the last 2-3 years**